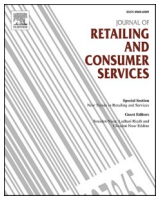
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Do you create your content yourself? Using generative artificial intelligence for social media content creation diminishes perceived brand authenticity

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ABSTRACT

Recent studies have demonstrated the potential of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) in enhancing marketing content. However, its impact on consumer behavior has remained empirically untested. In response to social media platforms mandating the disclosure of GenAI content, we investigate how followers perceive brands that use GenAI for content creation. Drawing from literature on algorithm aversion and brand authenticity, the results of three experimental studies indicate that brands' GenAI adoption induces negative attitudinal and behavioral follower reactions. These effects are mediated by followers' perceptions of brand authenticity and can be triggered by GenAI disclosure. Negative reactions are attenuated if GenAI is used to assist humans in content creation rather than to replace them through automation. Our findings underscore the need for nuance in brands' GenAI adoption to unlock economic benefits without compromising on relationships with consumers.

1. Introduction

Content creation with generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) is transforming how brands interact with consumers in digital spaces. For instance, designer Iris von Armin (2023) uses GenAI to promote fashion products in synthetic photoshoots on social media. Levi Strauss & Co (2023) presents clothing on customizable GenAI fashion models, and Amazon uses GenAI to craft engaging product listings (Amazon, 2023a) and ad images (Amazon, 2023b). Market research predicts that, by 2025, nearly one-third of major brands' marketing messages will be crafted by GenAI (Gartner, 2023). This rapid shift toward widespread adoption raises essential questions about how consumers react to brands that use GenAI for digital marketing communications.

GenAI can create meaningful content, such as text, images, audio, or videos. This novel development fundamentally expands the capabilities of previous AI technology, which focused on analytical decision-making tasks (Feuerriegel et al., 2023). Prior literature has provided a conceptual view of GenAI's transformative impact on marketing practice (Kshetri et al., 2023; Peres et al., 2023) and emphasized its vital role in social media content marketing (Wahid et al., 2023). The COVID-19 pandemic has profoundly shifted consumer–brand interactions toward online channels, where marketers can leverage GenAI to engage consumers through creative content at scale. For retailers that rely on a strong presence in digital spaces, it is crucial to understand follower perceptions of AI-generated content on social media (Guha et al., 2021).

Despite the increasing relevance of this topic, research currently lacks a basic understanding of whether and how the use of GenAI for content creation influences consumer–brand relationships (Wahid et al., 2023). Empirical work on GenAI content creation has mainly concentrated on two areas. One group of studies has examined how GenAI can support marketing professionals in performing content marketing, demonstrating positive effects on financial returns (Reisenbichler et al., 2022) as well as worker productivity and quality (Noy and Zhang, 2023). The other group has explored use cases for marketers, finding that GenAI may create value, for instance, by integrating artistic styles within visual marketing content (Wang et al., 2023) and automating the design of personalized persuasive messages (Matz et al., 2023). With regard to social media, recent literature reviews (Mariani et al., 2022; Vaid et al., 2023) have indicated that there is marketing research focused on leveraging analytical AI methods for content analytics, but there is still a need to investigate user reactions to creative GenAI content.

Addressing the outlined research gap is crucial as regulators call for transparency in GenAI adoption. For instance, an executive order by The White House (2023) aims to enforce clear disclosure of AI-generated content. Such regulation plays a decisive role in protecting and empowering consumers who, as demonstrated by Jakesch et al. (2023), can often no longer distinguish GenAI from human content. Today,

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social media platforms like TikTok (2023a) are already prescribing GenAI disclosures that, if not voluntarily given by brands, are assigned by platform providers when synthetic content is detected. Since these disclosures reveal GenAI adoption by brands to social media followers, research on consumer reactions is urgently needed to identify the potential pitfalls (Peres et al., 2023). As suggested by Wahid et al. (2023) and Silver et al. (2021), automating content creation traditionally performed by humans could diminish authenticity perceptions and thus reduce GenAI acceptance.

Against this background, the current paper breaks new ground by investigating how a brand's decision to adopt GenAI for social media content creation, rather than relying solely on human input, affects follower perceptions. Using three experimental studies, we investigated different types of social media brands, including corporate brands and influencers. Our findings provide robust evidence that attitudinal and behavioral follower reactions deteriorate when brands adopt GenAI. However, follower aversion decreases if GenAI is used to assist humans in content creation rather than to completely automate the process. Explaining these effects, we show that followers' negative reactions are mediated by attenuated brand authenticity perceptions, pointing to the impairment of the valuable relationships that brands aim to build with their followers. Our findings make a timely contribution to consumer behavior research by providing novel empirical evidence regarding consumers' aversion to GenAI adoption for creative endeavors and by delineating its nuanced facets. Considering disclosure guidelines that enhance users' recognition of GenAI content, we also provide actionable guidance for managers who are considering using GenAI in their social media content strategy.

In the following, we illustrate the novelty and relevance of GenAI for marketing content creation. Subsequently, we review prior research on consumers' aversion to AI applications to motivate the effect of brands' GenAI adoption on follower reactions on social media. Drawing on brand authenticity literature, we then formulate our mediation hypotheses before presenting three experimental studies: Study 1 investigates follower reactions to their favorite corporate brands' decision to adopt GenAI to automate content production, as opposed to not utilizing it, with an emphasis on perceived brand authenticity as the underlying mechanism. Study 2 replicates the effects of GenAI adoption for a concrete social media post by a fictitious brand. It tests whether consumers notice a difference between AI- and human-generated content and how consumer reactions are affected when GenAI content is disclosed as such. Study 3 replicates the methodology of Study 1 but focuses on influencers, and it introduces a third level of GenAI adoption, where GenAI is used to assist human content creation as opposed to scenarios where it is not used at all or used for complete automation. In the concluding section, we discuss the implications of our findings for theory and practice and highlight opportunities for future research at the emerging frontier of GenAI marketing.

2. Literature review and hypotheses

2.1. Generative AI content creation

GenAI content creation refers to the use of statistical models to generate novel content based on input data. Tools such as the chatbot ChatGPT or image generator Midjourney provide interfaces for GenAI content creation through natural language instructions, making the technology easily accessible and igniting widespread GenAI adoption (Feuerriegel et al., 2023). In marketing practice, GenAI is particularly effective for content marketing (Wahid et al., 2023), which involves digital content dissemination to satisfy consumer needs and nurture consumer–brand relationships (Hollebeek and Macky, 2019). A social media manager, for instance, may use ChatGPT to generate engaging captions for a new Instagram post and combine them with compelling images created by Midjourney.

With recent developments in GenAI (OpenAI, 2023), brands could automate the entire content creation process, from audience analysis to ideation to actual content design. This advancement presents brands with a pivotal decision regarding the extent of GenAI adoption (Wahid et al., 2023). Based on the degree of automation, three scenarios are conceivable: Brands could choose not to adopt GenAI, meaning that humans would be in complete control and there would be no automation through GenAI (no adoption scenario; according to Gartner (2023), this constitutes the status quo in business practice). Alternatively, brands could adopt GenAI to automate selected content creation tasks while maintaining human oversight (assistance scenario). Finally, brands could adopt GenAI to automate the entire content creation process, thus replacing human input (automation scenario).

Extant empirical research on GenAI marketing has focused on how companies could potentially use the technology. Matz et al. (2023) showed that GenAI can effectively create personalized, persuasive content at scale. Across various consumer characteristics, such as political ideologies and personality traits, ChatGPT was able to match ads to consumer profiles and exert a stronger influence on consumer behavior than non-personalized controls. Signifying a substantial step toward hyper-personalization, GenAI could build on consumer analytics to craft customized content in real time. Findings by Wang et al. (2023) suggest that brands could also leverage GenAI to strengthen their design language. The authors demonstrated that image generators can enhance consumer preferences by incorporating artistic styles into synthetic content. Therefore, on social media, brands could potentially use GenAI to emphasize characteristic imagery in postings.

While the outlined findings focused on technical capabilities of GenAI, other studies have demonstrated how GenAI could augment human labor. A recent article showed that ChatGPT significantly enhances the quality and productivity of workers in typical content marketing writing tasks (Noy and Zhang, 2023). Reisenbichler et al. (2022) investigated the efficacy of GenAI website content for search engine optimization. Their results showed that an assistance approach, combining AI-generated content with human refinement, outperformed human experts in search engine rankings while significantly lowering production costs.

In summary, early empirical findings underscore the transformative potential of GenAI for content marketing. Given its ability to produce high-quality, multimodal, and personalized content at scale, GenAI is poised to be adopted by brands to exploit automation potentials on social media (Feuerriegel et al., 2023). Although GenAI content can be indistinguishable from human content (Jakesch et al., 2023), disclosures such as those made by TikTok (2023a) reveal GenAI adoption to social media users. However, the literature still lacks a basic understanding of how social media followers react to brands that use GenAI for content creation.

2.2. Algorithm aversion and resistance to automation

Well before the rise of creative GenAI, analytical AI could already automate decision-making tasks. For marketing, companies have been using AI algorithms to analyze rich company and consumer data to perform automated actions such as product recommendations and targeted advertising (Overgoor et al., 2019). Due to the increasing prevalence of algorithms, research has investigated individual preferences for algorithmic decisions and came to an intriguing conclusion: People tend to distrust and reject algorithms, even if they outperform humans. These negative responses can occur because of psychological factors such as a general lack of trust in machines and algorithms (Mahmud et al., 2022) or individual expectations about algorithmic capabilities and functioning (Burton et al., 2020).

Summarized under the theoretical framework of algorithm aversion, this phenomenon has been demonstrated for various types of human–AI interactions. For example, people are less likely to adhere to medical advice provided by algorithms rather than human doctors, suspecting that AI cannot account for their unique conditions (Longoni et al., 2019).

Algorithm aversion has also been evidenced in finance, where people are more reluctant to hire financial robo-advisors (Zhang et al., 2021), and in moral decision contexts, where algorithmic decisions are perceived less favorably than human judgment (Jago, 2019). Aside from algorithmic decision-making, people have been found to display AI aversion in other instances of automation. For example, consumers evaluated service bots more negatively than human employees, expecting cost cutting motives at the expense of consumer benefits (Castelo et al., 2023). Moreover, when confronted with AI sales personnel, consumers perceived a lack of empathy and were less likely to engage in long sales calls (Li et al., 2023) or buy a firm's products (Luo et al., 2019).

Importantly, the outlined studies examined AI aversion to analytical decision-making and automation of non-creative human labor. However, the question remains how consumers perceive automated creation of brands' creative marketing content such as social media posts.

2.3. Aversion to generative AI adoption on social media

To understand reactions to GenAI content creation on social media, we consider previous findings on how task factors and context affect algorithm aversion. Consumers' identity motives constitute an important factor that has been shown to influence responses to task automation while also being essential for social media branding. Leung et al. (2018) found that people reject task automation if the consumption of output is driven by identity motives. Consumers that identified with a social category, such as being a cook, displayed more negative reactions to related automation technology than non-identifiers, as automation hindered the attribution of identity benefits. Similarly, Granulo et al. (2021) revealed lower preferences for automated task outputs if consumption was assigned high symbolic value, theorizing that human labor can better satisfy consumers' desire for uniqueness to foster self-expression.

Drawing parallels to social media, following a brand represents identity-driven consumption, in line with uses and gratifications theory and social identity theory. Uses and gratifications theory assumes that people are active in their choice of media and seek content whose associated qualities and social context gratify their needs (Katz et al., 1973). Following a brand is an active decision to engage with the brand's content which can be explained by users' motivations to reinforce and express identity (Muntinga et al., 2011). This connection coincides with social identity theory suggesting that followers of a brand identify as members of its community, thus satisfying a need for belonging (Ashforth and Mael, 1989). Likewise, brands can use social media communications for identity expression and consumer–brand relationship building (Roggeveen et al., 2021).

In their study on retail strategies to enhance consumer–brand identity congruence, Roggeveen et al. (2021) emphasized the fundamental role of creativity for engaging storytelling and forging a unique brand identity. Furthermore, Ashley and Tuten (2015) found that brands with high brand equity frequently weave experiential and emotional appeals into their social media content. Anthropomorphic cues (Kim et al., 2020; Kim and Park, 2024) and intimate self-disclosure (Kim and Song, 2016) have also been demonstrated essential content features for relationship building since they enhance users' feelings of social presence. The expectation that GenAI cannot produce such intimate and relatable content that facilitates follower–brand identification should negatively affect followers' responses to GenAI adoption, as suggested by Burton et al. (2020) and Castelo et al. (2019).

Mind perception research investigates how humans ascribe mental states to other entities like machines and AI, thereby indicating reasons why follower–brand identification could be impaired when GenAI assumes content creation. According to Bigman and Gray (2018), people judge AI as incapable of fully feeling or thinking. Most notably, compared with humans, machines are rated significantly lower in subjective experiences such as emotions, individuality, and consciousness (Gray et al., 2007), which Haslam et al. (2008) proposed to be human-nature attributes. Recently, Magni et al. (2023) showed that consumers ascribe lower creativity to visual artwork by AI versus human producers, suggesting that people see creative content creation as a task reserved for humans.

In light of these considerations, a brand's adoption of GenAI to undertake social media content creation may diminish its followers' sense of connection with the brand. These feelings result from the perception that GenAI lacks the intrinsic human qualities necessary for producing content that resonates deeply with followers' identity needs. In line with algorithm aversion literature (Mahmud et al., 2022), we anticipate negative follower reactions on attitudinal and behavioral dimensions crucial for social media marketing success. Specifically, we suggest that followers perceive brands that adopt GenAI to replace human content creation (automation scenario) as less credible and develop less favorable brand attitudes. Moreover, we expect followers to withdraw from interacting with such brands, resulting in lower intentions to engage in favorable electronic word of mouth (EWOM) and to remain loyal brand followers.

H1a. Adopting generative AI to automate (vs. no adoption) social media content creation attenuates favorable follower reactions, including perceived post credibility, brand attitudes, EWOM intentions, and brand loyalty.

Following a similar line of argumentation, the proposed negative effects of GenAI adoption should also occur if brands use GenAI to automate selected content creation tasks while maintaining human involvement (assistance scenario). GenAI adoption, whether in full automation or as an assistant, introduces a layer of artificiality and departure from a brand's traditional social media communications, which can threaten followers' identity-based consumption experiences. Yalcin et al. (2022) found that companies using AI for decision-making processes were evaluated less favorably by consumers, irrespective of whether AI acted in the presence or absence of humans. Paralleling these findings, we expect negative follower responses to brands that adopt GenAI to assist social media content creation.

H1b. Adopting generative AI to assist (vs. no adoption) social media content creation attenuates favorable follower reactions, including perceived post credibility, brand attitudes, EWOM intentions, and brand loyalty.

While both forms of GenAI adoption will likely elicit follower reactance, prior research has suggested that accentuating human involvement may attenuate algorithm aversion by increasing control over AI (Burton et al., 2020). For example, patients' negative evaluations of medical AI advice declined when AI was framed as assisting human doctors rather than replacing them (Longoni et al., 2019). Similar effects were reported in the context of AI product recommendations (Longoni and Cian, 2022). Involving humans alongside GenAI in the content creation process implies the potential for a brand to reduce the dilution of unique content characteristics that followers identify with but GenAI cannot create. We thus expect that followers' negative reactions to brands adopting GenAI, compared to them not using it, are weaker if the technology assists content creation rather than completely automates it.

H1c. Adopting generative AI to automate (vs. assist) social media content creation attenuates favorable follower reactions, including perceived post credibility, brand attitudes, EWOM intentions, and brand loyalty.

2.4. Social media brand authenticity

For social media brands, being perceived as authentic is paramount to build strong identity and relationships with followers (Campagna et al., 2023; Leung et al., 2022). Followers' authenticity perceptions have been linked to how content is created (Audrezet et al., 2020), and adopting GenAI for automated content creation might jeopardize these

perceptions (Wahid et al., 2023). In a conceptual review, Silver et al. (2021) explicitly suggested that changes in brand authenticity could be the causal reason underlying AI aversion evidenced in the automation of typically human work. To motivate a potential mediation process, we briefly introduce the construct of authenticity and review the consequences of brand authenticity perceptions. Subsequently, we outline prior marketing research that focused on authenticity antecedents related to how brands operate their businesses (e.g., creating products).

Authenticity refers to an entity's favorable trait of being true, real, or genuine, which is attributed by observers. People seek the consumption of authenticity (e.g., by following authentic brands) in expectation of identity benefits (Beverland and Farrelly, 2010). Prior research has found that brands (including human brands, which are professionally managed humans with brand-like attributes (Thomson, 2006)) derive significant value from authenticity. Positive consumer reactions include trust (Moulard et al., 2016) and favorable brand attitudes (Lee and Johnson, 2022; Morhart et al., 2015). Authenticity also positively affects behavioral outcomes, such as EWOM (Kumar and Kaushal, 2021; Lee and Johnson, 2022; Park et al., 2023) and purchase intentions (Kumar and Kaushal, 2021; Park et al., 2023).

Given the strong demand for authenticity, multiple studies have investigated the distinct drivers of authenticity perceptions. Consumers evaluate the authenticity of a brand based on the extent to which it matches their ideals (Moulard et al., 2021), which often reflects the operating philosophy they expect from the brand. Napoli et al. (2014) found that brands emphasizing quality and craftsmanship were viewed as more authentic. For instance, a sushi restaurant that showcases skilled sushi chefs exudes craft authenticity (Carroll and Wheaton, 2009), and wineries can signal authenticity through their passion for the craft of excellent winemaking (Beverland, 2005). For human brands, Moulard et al. (2014) suggested that the extent to which individuals show passionate commitment to their work enhances authenticity perceptions. Passionate authenticity management is also essential for social media influencers, especially amid rising commercialization (Audrezet et al., 2020). Besides being passionate and committed to craft, several studies highlighted the link between authenticity and temporal stability. Morhart et al. (2015) emphasized continuity as a vital aspect of brand authenticity. Similarly, Spiggle et al. (2012) stressed the significance of preserving brand essence, heritage, and consistent standards to foster an authentic image, and Moulard et al. (2015) defined consistent, time-stable behavior as a facet of human brand authenticity.

In essence, previous studies have found that brands are viewed as authentic when they demonstrate passion for their craft and maintain consistency in their operations. Deviations from this ideal induce inauthenticity perceptions (Silver et al., 2021). Real-world examples from social media brands echo the significance of passion and consistency. Mr. Beast, a renowned YouTuber with about 180 million subscribers, says that he is "hyper-obsessed" with social media content creation and contemplates it "every day, all day" (Rogan, 2022, 9:17). If Mr. Beast changed this characteristic behavior and adopted GenAI to craft social media content, followers would arguably update their authenticity perceptions.

We hypothesize that perceived brand authenticity mediates the negative effects of GenAI adoption by brands on followers' reactions, as proposed in H1a/b/c. This presupposes that followers see brands that delegate content creation to GenAI as less authentic due to a deviation from the ideal way of interacting with followers. In this spirit, Silver et al. (2021) state that "handmade craft embodies the essence of the creator, [but] the machine-made version has been adulterated by an unnatural process, even if it yields a more reliable and quality-controlled result" (p. 77). Due to attenuated brand authenticity perceptions, followers will likely exhibit less favorable attitudes and engage less with brands. Fig. 1 presents our conceptual model.

H2a. Perceived brand authenticity mediates the negative effect of generative AI adoption to automate (vs. no adoption) social media content creation on favorable follower reactions, including perceived post credibility, brand attitudes, EWOM intentions, and brand loyalty.

H2b. Perceived brand authenticity mediates the negative effect of generative AI adoption to assist (vs. no adoption) social media content creation on favorable follower reactions, including perceived post credibility, brand attitudes, EWOM intentions, and brand loyalty.

H2c. Perceived brand authenticity mediates the negative effect of generative AI adoption to automate (vs. assist) social media content creation on favorable follower reactions, including perceived post credibility, brand attitudes, EWOM intentions, and brand loyalty.

3. Study 1

3.1. Method

3.1.1. Design and procedure

We conducted a scenario-based online experiment in Qualtrics, wherein we separated the participants into two experimental groups (GenAI adoption: automation vs. no adoption). First, participants received a primer on GenAI, including a definition adapted from Feuerriegel et al. (2023), as well as information about its ability to support diverse tasks (e.g., translating texts and writing poems) and its rapid proliferation into business and society. The primer is displayed in Figure A1 in the appendix. We then asked each participant to take a moment and think about their favorite brand followed on social media. To increase situational involvement, the participants were instructed to visualize the brand's logo and its last three social media posts. Participants who could not think of a brand were screened out. Subsequently, we asked participants to talk more about their favorite brand on social media by writing down the brand's name (which we automatically embedded in later steps of the survey), the social media platforms on which they followed the brand, the type of content the brand posts, an aspect they particularly liked about the brand, and for how long they have been following the brand.

We then separated the participants into two groups to manipulate GenAI adoption. In the automation group, participants were told, "Imagine that [embedded brand name] began using Generative AI to automatically (without its significant involvement) create content for social media. This means that for certain posts, all steps—from the idea creation process to the actual content design—would be performed by Generative AI systems." In the no adoption group, participants were told, "Imagine that [embedded brand name] refused to use any Generative AI to create content for social media. This means that for all posts, no steps—from the idea creation process to the actual content design—would be performed by Generative AI systems." Afterward, we measured brand loyalty, intentions to engage in favorable EWOM, perceived post credibility, and perceived brand authenticity.

3.1.2. Sample

To investigate social media follower reactions to brands' GenAI adoption, our target population consisted of social media users actively following a brand. We used the subject pool by Prolific for recruitment, as the platform enables researchers to set flexible screening criteria and is known for high data quality (Palan and Schitter, 2018). We recruited 153 participants who fulfilled our screening criteria of having Prolific approval ratings of 100%, being English-speaking adults from the United States, using social media at least once per month, and actively following a brand on social media. Upon registration, we forwarded participants to our Qualtrics experiment, wherein we screened out 35

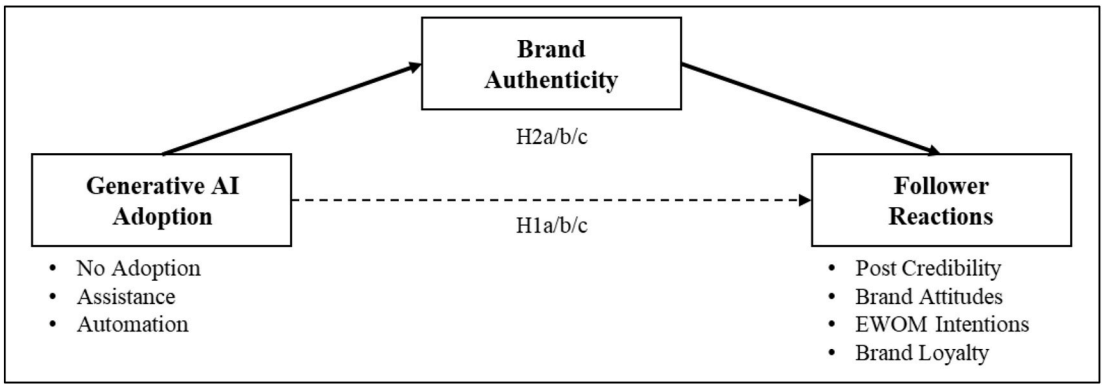


Fig. 1. Conceptual model.

participants who could not think of a favorite brand (see section 3.1.1), resulting in a sample of 118 participants (54% female, $M_{age} = 34.58$).[1] Upon completion, the participants received a small financial compensation for their participation. The experimental groups did not differ in gender ($X^2(2) = 4.27$, $p = 0.118$), age ($t(116) = 1.39$, $p = 0.167$), or prior GenAI experience ($X^2(1) = 1.68$, $p = 0.194$). With an approximately equal gender split and the middle 50% of the sample falling within the age range of 27–41 years (median = 32), our sample demographics closely matched those of our target population of social media users on major platforms such as Instagram (NapoleonCat, 2023).

3.1.3. Measures

We measured each of the following constructs on a seven-point agreement Likert scale (1 = *strongly disagree*, 7 = *strongly agree*). Perceived brand authenticity was assessed by the mean of three items ("[Embedded brand name] would still be genuine/real to me/ authentic," $\alpha = 0.97$, $M = 5.12$, $SD = 1.71$) from Moulard et al. (2015). We measured post credibility ("Posts by [embedded brand name] would still be trustworthy/honest/convincing," $\alpha = 0.97$, $M = 5.12$, $SD = 1.59$) and favorable EWOM intentions ("Posts by [embedded brand name] would still be worth sharing with others/I would still like posts by [brand name]/I would still comment positive feedback below posts by [embedded brand name]," $\alpha = 0.92$, $M = 4.96$, $SD = 1.61$) by adapting scales from Boerman et al. (2017). A single reversed item ("I would unfollow [embedded brand name]," $M = 5.62$, $SD = 1.60$) indicated brand loyalty. An overview of the construct measurements is provided in Table A1 in the appendix.

3.2. Results

To test H1a, we conducted independent sample t-tests to assess the total effect of GenAI adoption on perceived post credibility, EWOM intentions, and brand loyalty. In the automation scenario, perceived post credibility (automation: $M = 4.42$, $SD = 1.39$, no adoption: $M = 5.81$, $SD = 1.47$, $t(116) = 5.27$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.97$), EWOM intentions (automation: $M = 4.20$, $SD = 1.51$, no adoption: $M = 5.72$, $SD = 1.34$, $t(116) = 5.78$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 1.06$), and brand loyalty (automation: $M = 5.05$, $SD = 1.62$, no adoption: $M = 6.19$, $SD = 1.37$, $t(116) = 4.11$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.76$) were significantly lower than in the no adoption scenario, therefore supporting H1a for all follower reaction measures.

We ran Hayes' (2013) PROCESS macro (Model 4) to test the mediation hypothesis H2a. To probe the indirect effects, we used the percentile method with 10,000 bootstrap samples. Automation (vs. no adoption) reduced authenticity ($R^2 = 0.17$, $\beta = -1.40$, $p < 0.001$). Controlling for GenAI adoption, authenticity increased post credibility ($R^2 = 0.84$, $\beta = 0.82$, $p < 0.001$), EWOM intentions ($R^2 = 0.78$, $\beta = 0.77$, $p < 0.001$), and brand loyalty ($R^2 = 0.62$, $\beta = 0.73$, $p < 0.001$). The indirect effects of GenAI adoption through authenticity on all three dependent variables were statistically significant (post credibility: $\beta = -1.15$, 95%-CI = [−1.59, −0.69]; EWOM intentions: $\beta = -1.08$, 95%-CI = [−1.55, −0.63]; brand loyalty: $\beta = -1.02$, 95%-CI = [−1.50, −0.58]). GenAI adoption had no significant direct effects on post credibility ($\beta = -0.24$, $p = 0.068$) and brand loyalty ($\beta = -0.12$, $p = 0.554$) but reduced EWOM intentions ($\beta = -0.44$, $p = 0.006$). In summary, perceived brand authenticity mediated the effects of GenAI adoption on perceived post credibility (full mediation), EWOM intentions (partial mediation), and brand loyalty (full mediation), supporting H2a. Table 1 presents the mean values for the experimental groups. Fig. 2 illustrates the results of the mediation analysis.

3.3. Discussion

Study 1 demonstrated negative follower reactions to brands adopting GenAI to automate content creation. Compared to a brand's decision not to use GenAI, the decision to adopt GenAI detrimentally affected followers' perceived post credibility, EWOM intentions, and brand loyalty. Study 1 also highlighted the mediation role of brand authenticity perceptions. A limitation is that the participants did not respond to real-world GenAI adoption, such as an AI-generated social media post. Instead, they were asked to envision their favorite brands deciding to adopt GenAI or not adopt it. A common constraint in many experimental social media studies is that participants are confronted with concrete stimulus materials by brands they do not follow. Seeking to bolster our results' validity, we opted for a scenario-based design as it allowed us to draw conclusions about real social media followers of brands. To balance the insights and address the limitations of the scenario-based approach, we conducted Study 2 and examined responses to a concrete visual GenAI-created post from a fictitious brand.

Table 1
Study 1 experimental group means.

Study 1	Generative AI Adoption: No Adoption	Generative AI Adoption: Automation
Brand Authenticity	5.82 (1.54) [a]	4.42 (1.58) [a]
Post Credibility	5.81 (1.47) [a]	4.42 (1.39) [a]
EWOM Intentions	5.72 (1.34) [a]	4.20 (1.51) [a]
Brand Loyalty	6.19 (1.37) [a]	5.05 (1.62) [a]

Note: Cell values represent means with standard deviations in parentheses; Means with superscript [a] in the same row differ significantly at $p < 0.001$.

[1] A priori power analysis (power = 80%, $\alpha = 0.05$) with an expected effect size of Cohen's $d = 0.570$ yielded a sample size of n = 100. The expected effect size was derived from research by Li et al. (2023), given its recency, related research focus, and similar methodological approach.

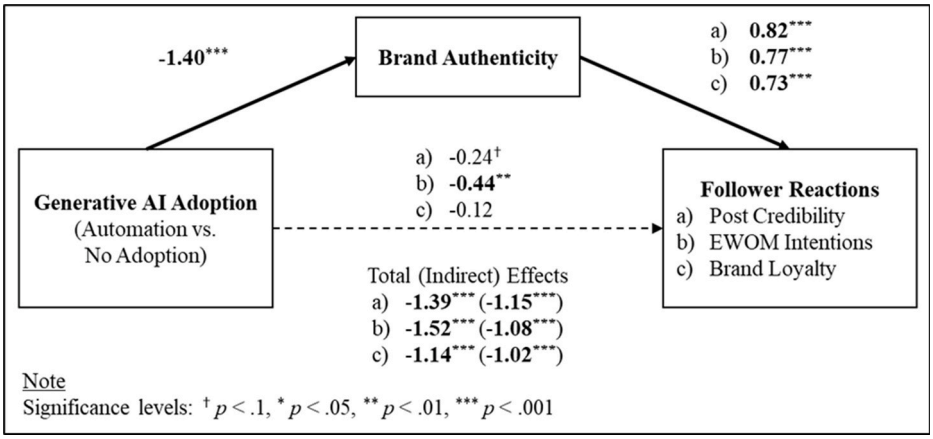


Fig. 2. Study 1 mediation analysis results.

4. Study 2

4.1. Pre-study

In our pre-study, we created GenAI stimulus materials by replicating an image from a professional fashion photoshoot and examined whether consumers could discern any differences between the GenAI image and the original. We selected a black dress from a European fashion brand showcased on the brand's online shop with two distinct images: The first (product shot) displayed the dress without a model against a white backdrop; in contrast, the second (model shot) featured a female model wearing the same dress in a professional photoshoot. Our objective was to replicate the model shot using only the product shot, essentially attempting to generate a professional photoshoot visualization from just the product image. To achieve this, we used a combination of ChatGPT and Midjourney. The replication process was as follows:

1) We inserted the public Midjourney manual on prompt writing into ChatGPT to train it on how to craft Midjourney text prompts for image creation. 2) We instructed ChatGPT that we wanted to create an image mirroring a photoshoot of a female model wearing the dress from the product shot. After specifying the appearance of the photoshoot through a brief description of the original model shot (e.g., model and scene characteristics, such as the pose and background), we asked ChatGPT to create a Midjourney prompt to generate the desired image. 3) We inserted the ChatGPT-generated prompt along with the product shot as inputs into Midjourney, which yielded the GenAI replicate of the model shot. Fig. 3 illustrates the recreation process.

Using the same procedure on Prolific as in Study 1, we recruited 131 participants (47% female, M_{age} = 39.41) to ask them about their perceptions of the two model shot variants in a two-group experiment (image: GenAI vs. original). The groups did not differ in gender ($X^2(2) = 0.42, p = 0.812$), age ($t(129) = 0.40, p = 0.693$), or prior experience with GenAI ($X^2(1) = 0.0$, $p = 1.0$). Participants were informed that they would see a photoshoot image from a fashion brand intended for posting on the brand's online shop and social media channels. Subsequently, participants were randomly presented with either the GenAI image or the original. We then asked participants on a seven-point agreement Likert scale (1 = *strongly disagree*, 7 = *strongly agree*) about their perceptions of the image. Perceived passion invested in content creation included the mean of two items ("The picture of the fashion model was made with passion/love," α = 0.92, M = 4.84, SD = 1.24) from de Kerviler et al. (2022). Perceived professionalism ("The picture of the fashion model looks professional," M = 6.21, SD = 0.88) and fit for the brand's online appearance ("The picture of the fashion model would fit well in [anonymized brand name]'s online shop and social media," M = 6.12, SD = 0.94) were measured through single items. We then showed the image again, provided the GenAI primer used in Study 1, and asked participants whether they believed the image was created with or without GenAI (62.60% answered, "The picture was created with Generative AI").

A one-way MANOVA (Pillai's Trace = 0.03, $F(3,127) = 1.26$, p = 0.291) revealed no significant differences between the two groups in terms of perceived passion (original: M = 4.73, SD = 1.29, GenAI: M = 4.96, SD = 1.17), professionalism (original: M = 6.27, SD = 0.98, GenAI:

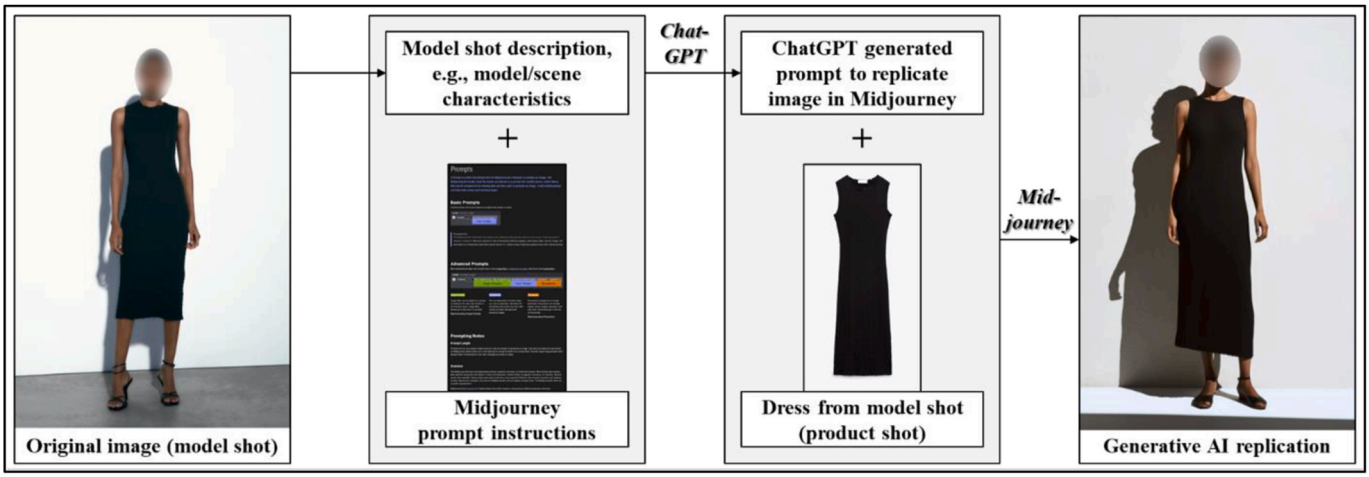


Fig. 3. GenAI image recreation process (anonymized).

$M = 6.14$, $SD = 0.75$), and fit (original: $M = 6.10$, $SD = 1.10$, GenAI: $M = 6.14$, $SD = 0.73$). Similarly, there was no significant relationship between the variant displayed and perceptions that the photo was created with GenAI (original: 67.16%, GenAI: 57.81%, $X^2(1) = 0.86$, $p = 0.355$). Table 2 presents the mean values for the experimental groups. These results indicate that consumers cannot perceptually differentiate GenAI from human content and rate them equally on dimensions related to perceived invested passion, professionalism, and fit for marketing purposes. In the main part of Study 2, we aimed to test whether participants' perceptions of GenAI content depended on whether a disclosure revealed GenAI adoption or lack thereof.

4.2. Method

4.2.1. Design and procedure

The participants were divided into two groups (GenAI adoption: automation vs. no adoption). As stimulus materials, we embedded the GenAI image from the pre-study in an Instagram post by the fictitious brand InnoStitch (see Figure A2 in the appendix). After receiving the primer on GenAI from Study 1, participants were told that they would see a recent post by the clothing brand InnoStitch. In the automation group, participants received a disclosure of GenAI adoption: "The upcoming post was produced using Generative AI. This means that the visual content does not represent a real-life photoshoot or an actual model. Rather, the image is the result of a computer program's autonomous generation process." In the no adoption group, participants were informed, "The upcoming post was produced traditionally, without the use of Generative AI. This means that the visual content is the result of a real-life photoshoot and features an actual model. The image was crafted by human professionals." We then showed the Instagram post by InnoStitch and measured the participants' responses.

4.2.2. Sample

Using the same procedure on Prolific as in Study 1 and an additional filter for female participants, we recruited a sample of 111 female social media users ($M_{age} = 39.44$). Since the stimulus materials displayed a women's fashion dress, we focused on female participants who typically have relevant experiences, needs, and perspectives related to shopping and wearing such clothing. Thus, we aimed to align the sample with the product's actual market segment and capture valid insights into the effects of GenAI adoption on the product's end-user experiences. Focusing on female participants has been a common procedure in previous research on consumer behavior in women's clothing contexts (e.g., Harman and Porter, 2021; Lv et al., 2022). The experimental groups did not differ significantly in age ($t(109) = 1.87$, $p = 0.064$) or prior experience with GenAI ($t(109) = 1.29$, $p = 0.201$).

4.2.3. Measures

All constructs were assessed on a seven-point agreement Likert scale (1 = *strongly disagree*, 7 = *strongly agree*): We used Study 1's measures of perceived brand authenticity ($\alpha = 0.96$, $M = 4.69$, $SD = 1.63$), post credibility ($\alpha = 0.96$, $M = 4.66$, $SD = 1.65$), and favorable EWOM intentions ($\alpha = 0.92$, $M = 4.00$, $SD = 1.68$) and adapted them to reference InnoStitch. Given the fictitious brand context, we replaced the brand loyalty measure with favorable brand attitudes by adapting three items ("InnoStitch is likable/InnoStitch seems pleasant to me/InnoStitch products are of high quality," $\alpha = 0.94$, $M = 4.82$, $SD = 1.46$) from Campbell (1995). The perceived passion scale was the same as in the pre-study ($\alpha = 0.94$, $M = 3.71$, $SD = 1.64$).

Table 2
Study 2 (pre-study) experimental group means.

Study 2 (Pre-Study)	Original Image	Generative AI Image
Perceived Passion	4.73 (1.29)	4.96 (1.17)
Perceived Professionalism	6.27 (0.98)	6.14 (0.75)
Perceived Fit	6.10 (1.10)	6.14 (0.73)
Perceived as Generative AI$_a$	67.16%	57.81%

Note: Cell values represent means with standard deviations in parentheses; $_a$ = percentage of respondents selecting, "The picture was created with Generative AI" (vs. without).

4.3. Results

We applied the testing procedure from Study 1. In the automation scenario, perceived post credibility (automation: $M = 4.28$, $SD = 1.90$, no adoption: $M = 5.04$, $SD = 1.27$, $t(109) = 2.49$, $p = 0.014$, Cohen's $d = 0.47$) and brand attitudes (automation: $M = 4.42$, $SD = 1.67$, no adoption: $M = 5.20$, $SD = 1.11$, $t(109) = 2.89$, $p = 0.005$, Cohen's $d = 0.55$) were lower than in the no adoption scenario. EWOM intentions did not differ significantly (automation: $M = 3.85$, $SD = 1.86$, no adoption: $M = 4.14$, $SD = 1.49$, $t(109) = 0.89$, $p = 0.378$, Cohen's $d = 0.17$). Hence, the results supported H1a for all follower reaction metrics besides EWOM intentions. We also found that perceived passion for content creation was significantly lower when participants were told that InnoStitch had used GenAI for the post (automation: $M = 3.15$, $SD = 1.69$, no adoption: $M = 4.25$, $SD = 1.39$, $t(109) = 3.73$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.71$).

Testing mediation, automation reduced perceived brand authenticity ($R^2 = 0.12$, $\beta = -1.12$, $p < 0.001$), which, controlling for GenAI adoption, increased post credibility ($R^2 = 0.77$, $\beta = 0.92$, $p < 0.001$), brand attitudes ($R^2 = 0.70$, $\beta = 0.76$, $p < 0.001$), and EWOM intentions ($R^2 = 0.44$, $\beta = 0.72$, $p < 0.001$). The indirect effects of GenAI adoption through authenticity on all dependent variables were statistically significant, supporting H2a (post credibility: $\beta = -1.02$, 95%-CI = [−1.59, −0.49]; brand attitudes: $\beta = -0.85$, 95%-CI = [−1.35, −0.39]; EWOM intentions: $\beta = -0.81$, 95%-CI = [−1.28, −0.38]). GenAI adoption had no significant direct effects on post credibility ($\beta = 0.26$, $p = 0.105$) and brand attitudes ($\beta = 0.07$, $p = 0.666$) but enhanced EWOM intentions ($\beta = 0.53$, $p = 0.042$). Summarizing Study 2, perceived brand authenticity completely mediated the effects of GenAI adoption on post credibility and brand attitudes. While GenAI adoption indirectly mitigated EWOM intentions through perceived authenticity, we found a competitive positive direct effect, accounting for the non-significant total effect. Table 3 presents the mean values for the experimental groups.

4.4. Discussion

In Study 2, we illustrated how brands could use a simple combination of GenAI applications to create marketing content (a photoshoot to promote a dress), which participants could not distinguish from human content. Despite participants not noticing a perceptual difference, when the content was disclosed as AI-generated, their authenticity perceptions of the fictitious brand and subsequent responses were more negative than when the content was labeled as human-made. Unlike in Study 1, however, the total effect on EWOM intentions was not significant, possibly due to the missing relationship with the fictitious brand that

Table 3
Study 2 experimental group means.

Study 2	Generative AI Adoption: No Adoption	Generative AI Adoption: Automation
Perceived Passion	4.25 (1.39) ^{c}	3.15 (1.69) ^{c}
Brand Authenticity	5.24 (1.27) ^{c}	4.13 (1.76) ^{c}
Post Credibility	5.04 (1.27) ^{a}	4.28 (1.90) ^{a}
Brand Attitudes	5.20 (1.11) ^{b}	4.42 (1.67) ^{b}
EWOM Intentions	4.14 (1.49)	3.85 (1.86)

Note: Cell values represent means with standard deviations in parentheses; Means with superscript $^a/^b/^c$ in the same row differ significantly at $p < 0.05/p < 0.01/p < 0.001$.

would be necessary to induce behavioral actions such as post-engagement (Cheung et al., 2022). In summary, Study 2 underlined the influence of GenAI disclosure on consumers' assessment of social media content. It also provided complementary evidence to Study 1 by showing that the detrimental impact of GenAI adoption manifests for concrete AI-disclosed content.

We conducted Study 3 to assess if followers react differently when GenAI is used to assist humans in content creation, in addition to GenAI being used not at all or for complete automation. Furthermore, we expanded our analysis to encompass influencers, seeking to test the robustness of our findings and their generalizability across different social media brands and follower–brand relationships. Influencers are prominent content creators and stand out due to their human brand character and relatability which can enhance personal connection (Ki et al., 2020). We anticipated that similar mechanisms and effects would apply for both corporate brands and influencers, given the congruent authenticity antecedents outlined in our literature review and the fundamentally similar nature as social media brands—including the creation of creative content for branding, socially interacting with audiences, and leveraging followers for marketing purposes (Gensler et al., 2013; Leung et al., 2022). To provide a more comprehensive understanding of GenAI adoption and reveal potential differences in follower perceptions, it is, however, important to consider influencers in addition to corporate brands.

5. Study 3

5.1. Method

5.1.1. Design and procedure

We adapted the scenario-based experiment from Study 1 to investigate followers' favorite influencers and added a third experimental group for GenAI adoption to assist content creation (GenAI adoption: automation vs. assistance vs. no adoption). In the assistance condition, participants were told, "Imagine that [embedded influencer name] began using Generative AI to assist him/her to create content for social media. This means that for some posts, selected steps—such as the idea creation process or the actual content design—would be performed by Generative AI systems." The automation and no adoption manipulations followed Study 1.

5.1.2. Sample

Using the same procedure on Prolific as in Study 1, except the participants had to be followers of an influencer rather than a corporate brand, we recruited a sample of 190 participants (48% female, M_{age} = 32.05).[2] The experimental groups showed no significant differences in terms of gender ($X^2(4) = 1.78$ $p = 0.776$), age ($F(2,187) = 0.0$, $p = 1.0$), or prior experience with GenAI ($X^2(2) = 0.52$, $p = 0.772$).

5.1.3. Measures

We used Study 1's measures for perceived brand authenticity ($\alpha = 0.95$, $M = 4.48$, $SD = 1.87$), perceived post credibility ($\alpha = 0.96$, $M = 4.57$, $SD = 1.78$), EWOM intentions ($\alpha = 0.94$, $M = 4.73$, $SD = 1.62$), and brand loyalty ($M = 5.20$, $SD = 1.74$), and adapted them to influencers.

5.2. Results

One-way ANOVA tests demonstrated a significant influence of GenAI adoption on perceived post credibility ($F(2,187) = 20.91$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.18$), EWOM intentions ($F(2,187) = 18.61$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.17$), and brand loyalty ($F(2,187) = 15.35$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.14$). Planned contrasts revealed that automation (vs. no adoption) decreased perceived post credibility (automation: $M = 3.61$, $SD = 1.77$, no adoption: $M = 5.47$, $SD = 1.52$, $t(187) = 6.45$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 1.14$), EWOM intentions (automation: $M = 3.94$, $SD = 1.64$, no adoption: $M = 5.56$, $SD = 1.43$, $t(187) = 6.10$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 1.08$), and brand loyalty (automation: $M = 4.42$, $SD = 1.89$, no adoption: $M = 6.02$, $SD = 1.37$, $t(187) = 5.54$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.98$). Similarly, assistance (vs. no adoption) decreased perceived post credibility (assistance: $M = 4.65$, $SD = 1.56$, $t(187) = 2.84$, $p = 0.005$, Cohen's $d = 0.51$), EWOM intentions (assistance: $M = 4.70$, $SD = 1.38$, $t(187) = 3.21$, $p = 0.002$, Cohen's $d = 0.57$), and brand loyalty (assistance: $M = 5.17$, $SD = 1.55$, $t(187) = 2.91$, $p = 0.004$, Cohen's $d = 0.52$). Contrasting automation with assistance, we found significant differences for all follower reactions, including perceived post credibility ($t(187) = 3.60$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.64$), EWOM intentions ($t(187) = 2.88$, $p = 0.004$, Cohen's $d = 0.51$), and brand loyalty ($t(187) = 2.62$, $p = 0.010$, Cohen's $d = 0.46$). In conclusion, the results support H1a/b/c.

We ran separate mediation models for the different contrasts. Testing H2a, automation (vs. no adoption) reduced perceived brand authenticity ($R^2 = 0.25$, $\beta = -2.0$, $p < 0.001$), which—controlling for GenAI adoption—increased post credibility ($R^2 = 0.85$, $\beta = 0.84$, $p < 0.001$), EWOM intentions ($R^2 = 0.68$, $\beta = 0.67$, $p < 0.001$), and brand loyalty ($R^2 = 0.60$, $\beta = 0.66$, $p < 0.001$). The indirect effects of automation through brand authenticity on all dependent variables were significant (post credibility: $\beta = -1.68$, 95%-CI = [−2.20, −1.15]; EWOM intentions: $\beta = -1.34$, 95%-CI = [−1.86, −0.86]; brand loyalty: $\beta = -1.33$, 95%-CI = [−1.86, −0.85]), whereas the direct effects were insubstantial (post credibility: $\beta = -0.17$, $p = 0.246$; EWOM intentions: $\beta = -0.27$, $p = 0.179$; brand loyalty: $\beta = -0.27$, $p = 0.270$).

Testing H2b, assistance (vs. no adoption) attenuated brand authenticity ($R^2 = 0.09$, $\beta = -0.98$, $p < 0.001$), which increased post credibility ($R^2 = 0.81$, $\beta = 0.87$, $p < 0.001$), EWOM intentions ($R^2 = 0.54$, $\beta = 0.63$, $p < 0.001$), and brand loyalty ($R^2 = 0.52$, $\beta = 0.64$, $p < 0.001$). All indirect effects were significant (post credibility: $\beta = -0.85$, 95%-CI = [−1.33, −0.38]; EWOM intentions: $\beta = -0.61$, 95%-CI = [−1.03, −0.25]; brand loyalty: $\beta = -0.63$, 95%-CI = [−1.08, −0.26]), whereas the direct effects were not significant (post credibility: $\beta = 0.03$, $p = 0.80$; EWOM intentions: $\beta = -0.24$, $p = 0.205$; brand loyalty: $\beta = -0.21$, $p = 0.282$).

Testing H2c, automation (vs. assistance) reduced brand authenticity ($R^2 = 0.08$, $\beta = -1.02$, $p = 0.001$), which enhanced post credibility ($R^2 = 0.76$, $\beta = 0.83$, $p < 0.001$), EWOM intentions ($R^2 = 0.65$, $\beta = 0.70$, $p < 0.001$), and brand loyalty ($R^2 = 0.56$, $\beta = 0.74$, $p < 0.001$). The indirect effects were statistically significant (post credibility: $\beta = -0.85$, 95%-CI = [−1.34, −0.35]; EWOM intentions: $\beta = -0.72$, 95%-CI = [−1.16, −0.29]; brand loyalty: $\beta = -0.75$, 95%-CI = [−1.22, −0.31]). None of the direct effects was significant (post credibility: $\beta = -0.19$, $p = 0.245$; EWOM intentions: $\beta = -0.04$, $p = 0.797$; brand loyalty: $\beta = 0.00$, $p = 0.994$). Summarizing Study 3, the more pronounced the role of GenAI in content creation (automation > assistance > no adoption), the more negative were follower reactions, supporting H1a/b/c. Perceived authenticity fully mediated the effects on post credibility, EWOM intentions, and brand loyalty, supporting H2/a/b/c. Fig. 4 depicts the group means for the dependent variables. Table 4 presents the mean values for the experimental groups.

5.3. Discussion

Study 3 expanded our findings' generalizability across different social media actors by replicating negative follower reactions to GenAI adoption for influencers in addition to corporate brands. Moreover, evaluating the effect of using GenAI to assist humans, Study 3 illustrated that follower reactions are nuanced and depend on GenAI's role in content creation. The greater the degree of task automation through GenAI, the more negative were followers' brand authenticity perceptions as well as attitudinal and behavioral reactions.

[2] A priori power analysis (power = 80%, $\alpha = 0.05$) with an expected effect size of Cohen's $f = 0.285$ (Li et al., 2023) yielded a sample size of n = 123.

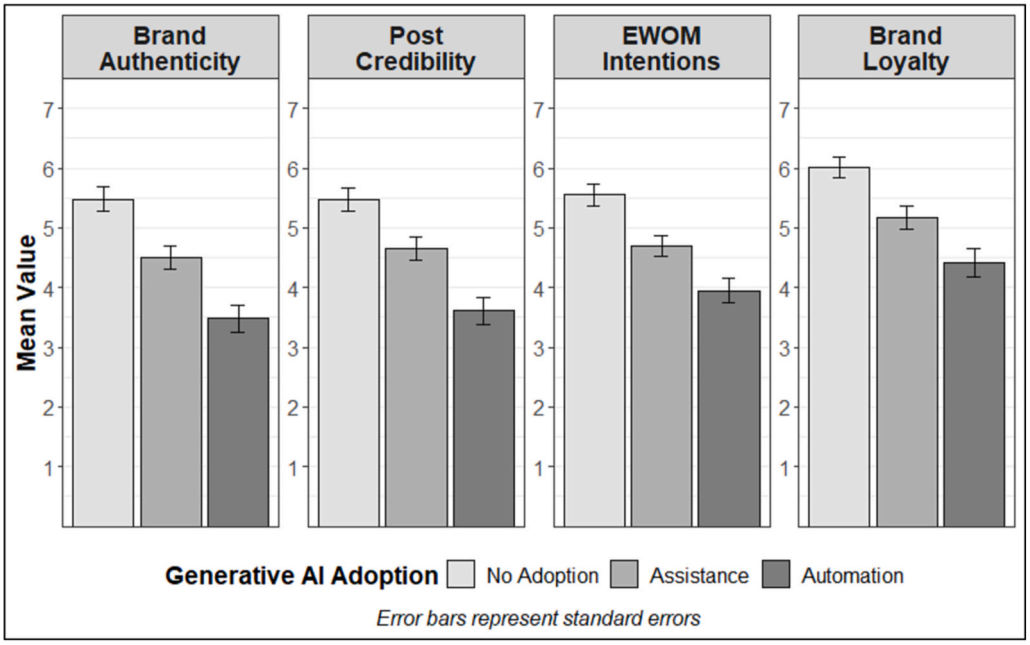


Fig. 4. Study 3 experimental group means.

Table 4
Study 3 experimental group means.

Study 3	Generative AI Adoption: No Adoption	Generative AI Adoption: Assistance	Generative AI Adoption: Automation
Brand Authenticity	5.48 (1.63) ^{ab}	4.50 (1.53) ^{ab}	3.48 (1.88) ^{b}
Post Credibility	5.47 (1.52) ^{ab}	4.65 (1.56) ^{ab}	3.61 (1.77) ^{b}
EWOM Intentions	5.56 (1.43) ^{ab}	4.70 (1.38) ^{a}	3.94 (1.64) ^{ab}
Brand Loyalty	6.02 (1.37) ^{ab}	5.17 (1.55) ^{a}	4.42 (1.89) ^{ab}

Note: Cell values represent means with standard deviations in parentheses; Means with superscript $^{a}/^{b}$ in the same row differ significantly at $p < 0.01/p < 0.001$.

6. General discussion

With the rise of GenAI technologies, marketers can now craft meaningful content for creative purposes, significantly extending the capabilities of analytical AI used for decision-making (Feuerriegel et al., 2023). As consumers are directly being exposed to GenAI marketing content and disclosure regulations (The White House, 2023; TikTok, 2023a) are making brands' GenAI adoption transparent, it is of utmost importance for marketing researchers to investigate consumer reactions (Peres et al., 2023). In the current paper, we aimed to address the gap in empirical research on consumer perceptions of GenAI adoption for social media marketing, an issue Guha et al. (2021) suggested as being pivotal for the future of retailing.

Across our three studies, we consistently demonstrated that consumers value the human craft of social media content creation over GenAI. A key discovery was that, while consumers struggle to distinguish between human and GenAI content based on perception alone (see the pre-study results of Study 2), they find brands that automate content creation through GenAI less authentic than brands that do not use GenAI. This outcome can be triggered by disclosing a post as AI-generated, a finding that gains significance in the context of regulatory movements toward GenAI disclosure. We also showed that attenuated brand authenticity perceptions induced by GenAI adoption trigger negative consumer attitudes and behaviors, including diminished credibility of posts, less favorable brand attitudes, a lower likelihood of engaging in positive EWOM, and reduced brand loyalty. The results are substantial and robust across different social media brand types, including consumers' favorite corporate brands and influencers that they follow as well as fictitious brands with which consumers had no previous relationships. Only the total effect of GenAI adoption on EWOM intentions was not significant for the fictitious brand, which may be explained by the lack of consumer–brand relationships needed for brand-related activities such as EWOM (Cheung et al., 2022). Moreover, we showed that follower reactions depend on whether brands adopt GenAI as well as on how they use it. If GenAI is adopted to assist rather than to replace humans in content creation, follower judgments of brand authenticity and subsequent reactions are less negative. This finding emphasizes the importance of human–AI collaboration to maintain relational consumer–brand relationships in the face of technological advancement.

6.1. Theoretical contributions

Our findings make three substantial theoretical contributions. First, our paper presents a pioneering exploration of follower reactions to brands' GenAI adoption for social media content creation. Casting light on the crucially important consumer behavior perspective, we extended the growing body of literature on GenAI marketing (Matz et al., 2023; Noy and Zhang, 2023; Reisenbichler et al., 2022; Wang et al., 2023) that, so far, has only focused on how companies can use the technology to enhance content creation. We thereby respond to calls for research by Peres et al. (2023) and Wahid et al. (2023) and investigate a subject identified as paramount for the future of retailing by Guha et al. (2021). Grounding our research in the theoretical framework of algorithm aversion (Burton et al., 2020; Mahmud et al., 2022), we uncovered that followers resist GenAI adoption in the creative realms of content creation and follower–brand interactions on social media. This finding is consistent with the notion that following a brand represents identity-driven consumption (Muntinga et al., 2011) and mind perception research (Bigman and Gray, 2018; Gray et al., 2007) suggesting that

AI is perceived as incapable of producing intimate content essential for brand identity and relationship building. Our research context diverges significantly from previous studies on algorithm aversion in analytical decision-making tasks and non-creative labor automation. Consequently, our work contributes to creating a more profound understanding of consumer resistance to AI adoption for brands' creative pursuits.

Second, we contribute to brand authenticity theory by unveiling how impaired authenticity perceptions drive social media followers' resistance to GenAI-adopting brands. Prior conceptual work suggested that the automation of traditional human tasks through AI might erode authenticity (Silver et al., 2021; Wahid et al., 2023). Our paper provides empirical evidence to confirm this hypothesis in the context of GenAI content creation. Moulard et al. (2021) indicated that brands benefit from authenticity attributions when remaining true-to-ideal, which may be emphasized by passion (Audrezet et al., 2020) and continuity (Morhart et al., 2015). Our findings suggest that GenAI-adopting brands deviate from the content ideals of followers, which initially attracted them and provided identity benefits. In essence, we bridged brand authenticity theory with the framework of algorithm aversion to enhance the theoretical understanding of GenAI's detrimental influence on follower–brand relationships.

Third, our findings point to boundary conditions of GenAI aversion by showing that follower reactions vary based on how brands utilize GenAI. The technology might disrupt content creation by replacing creative workers, and it is critical to clarify the role of humans in this transformative environment (Wahid et al., 2023). From a consumer behavior perspective, our results highlight social media followers' appreciation of human involvement. We showed that the negative impact of GenAI on brand authenticity perceptions attenuates when GenAI is adopted to assist, rather than to replace, human creatives. Hence, our paper complements prior research in the context of AI recommendations (Longoni et al., 2019; Longoni and Cian, 2022) by emphasizing the significance of human–AI collaboration in brands' creative endeavors.

6.2. Managerial implications

The enthusiasm by marketers for GenAI technology is widespread and understandable, given its potential to increase efficiency and creativity in content creation (Feuerriegel et al., 2023). However, as Peres et al. (2023) pointed out, it is vital to consider potential challenges related to consumer reactions, especially in early stages of GenAI adoption. Our paper offers actionable managerial guidance for GenAI usage, emphasizing 1) the importance of caution due to potential negative consumer responses as well as 2) the necessity of communicating human involvement and 3) maintaining brand authenticity.

Investigating follower–brand relationships on social media, we underscore that using GenAI for content creation can lead to negative brand and content evaluations as well as consumer disengagement. Due to the transparency about GenAI usage caused by disclosure regulations, brands are confronted with a balancing act to leverage GenAI's benefits for content creation without jeopardizing favorable relationships with consumers. For example, the apparel retailer Levi Strauss & Co (2023) recently announced using GenAI to match the appearance of fashion models to consumer characteristics, aiming to personalize the shopping experience. However, the brand encountered significant backlash with critics calling the decision to adopt GenAI problematic and lazy (Clark, 2023). To reduce negative reactions, we advise managers to approach GenAI thoughtfully and strategically rather than rushing to adopt it. Incorporating pilot testing as well as continuous monitoring and feedback mechanisms would help remaining attuned to consumer sentiment. Managers could also employ co-creation initiatives, such as social media polls where followers contribute ideas to guide GenAI content generation, enhancing GenAI acceptance and fostering a sense of ownership among followers.

Furthermore, integrating human professionals in the GenAI content creation process and communicating that GenAI assists and augments human input is a key strategy to minimize consumers' reactance. For example, the retailer Amazon using GenAI to create potential captions and visuals for an Instagram post could benefit from a manager's expertise in refining the best options. Effectively communicating this human–AI collaborative approach through hashtags like #draftedbyAIrefinedbyhumans or general statement posts could help foster a transparent dialogue on GenAI's evolving role in marketing communications. Levi Strauss & Co (2023), for instance, responded to consumer backlash by declaring its commitment to human professionals. The brand acknowledged consumers' sensitivity around GenAI but explicitly noted that GenAI would assist, not automate, human content creation.

Finally, our results highlight changes in perceived authenticity as the causal mechanism underlying detrimental consumer reactions. Therefore, bolstering brand authenticity constitutes a crucial task for managers seeking to adopt GenAI. Signaling the brand's passion for craft (Audrezet et al., 2020) and continuity (Morhart et al., 2015) could provide an authenticity bonus and offset negative responses to GenAI. For example, the fashion retail brand Iris von Armin (2023) recently posted AI-generated photoshoots on Instagram, revealing GenAI adoption through the hashtag #AIgenerated. The post's caption underlined that GenAI does not contrast the brand's craft but rather empowers its pursuit of creative endeavors. Similarly, responding to consumer backlash, Levi Strauss & Co (2023) emphasized the brand's continuous commitment to authentic storytelling and that GenAI enhances rather than impairs it.

In conclusion, we recommend that a strategic approach to GenAI adoption, communicating human involvement and protecting brand authenticity while actively monitoring and integrating consumer feedback, is critical for managers to ensure a more favorable reception of GenAI marketing initiatives.

6.3. Limitations and future research

Our work is not without limitations, which poses fruitful avenues for future research. We used an experimental approach to investigate our research question. In Studies 1 and 3, we asked participants to envision a scenario in which their favorite social media brands decided to either adopt or not adopt GenAI for content creation. This method allowed us to study real brand followers and gauge the effects of GenAI adoption on established relationships and authenticity perceptions. Future work should analyze follower responses to actual social media brand posts to improve external validity. In Study 2, we aimed to provide indications by disclosing GenAI adoption for a fictitious brand's social media post. As GenAI disclosures become increasingly enforced in the future, researchers could use secondary data from social media platforms and apply econometric methods to model the impact of AI-generated content on user engagement. For now, our experimental findings offer informative insights for marketing researchers and practitioners into the potential risks of GenAI adoption and the psychological mechanisms related to authenticity perceptions.

Our findings reflect early consumer responses to GenAI adoption, a technology that is distinct from previously researched analytical AI (Feuerriegel et al., 2023). Conducted in spring 2023, our studies capture a moment when mainstream attention toward GenAI was just beginning. As consumers become more familiar with GenAI, it will become clearer whether they accept or reject the technology (Feuerriegel et al., 2023). With further development and proliferation into business practice, GenAI could become part of consumers' ideal of content creation, removing any perceptions of authenticity violations. Castelo et al. (2023) suggested a potential shift from aversion to appreciation if AI unambiguously outperforms human craft. Thus, we encourage longitudinal studies to track evolving consumer responses to GenAI.

We also emphasize the need to study the effects of GenAI disclosure design on consumer reactions. Currently, there are no standardized

regulations on social media platforms. For instance, TikTok (2023b) suggests labels like "fake," "synthetic," or "altered." The chosen wording could affect consumer reactions, in that "fake" might be seen negatively and inauthentic. "Altered" implies that the basic post was created by humans, and GenAI helped to assist and refine the process, potentially reducing detrimental reactions. Our study used textual disclosure to inform participants about GenAI adoption. Similar to sponsorship disclosure studies (e.g., Eisend et al., 2020), future research could apply in-post-disclosures and test the effects of wording, positioning, and visual layout on GenAI recognition to guide policymakers and strengthen consumer protection.

Exploring the effects of GenAI adoption across different follower segments and brand types might help increase the generalizability of our findings. Prior research by Liu et al. (2023) found that algorithm aversion is influenced by culture and individual differences. In a related way, followers' reactions to GenAI content creation are shaped by perceptions of brand authenticity, which might depend on cultural values and brand nature. For instance, cultures emphasizing tradition and artisanal craft (e.g., Italy) could react more negatively to brands' GenAI adoption than technophile cultures (e.g., Singapore). Furthermore, GenAI content might seem more fitting for innovative brands (e.g., Apple) than for heritage ones (e.g., Rolex). Testing these hypotheses through cross-cultural and diverse brand studies would advance the theoretical understanding of consumer reactions to GenAI marketing.

Finally, we encourage future research to replicate and extend our findings using larger sample sizes. Across three experimental studies, we found converging empirical evidence pointing to predominantly medium to large effect sizes, as assumed in power analysis. However, our relatively small sample sizes pose a limitation in that we lack statistical power to test potentially smaller moderating effects such as whether tech-savviness influences follower reactions to GenAI adoption.

7. Conclusion

Our paper makes a timely contribution to consumer behavior research in the emerging frontier of GenAI marketing. While prior work outlined promising potential in marketing content creation, consumer reactions to brands using GenAI has remained unexplored. To address this gap, we investigated how followers respond to GenAI adoption on social media. This area is poised for GenAI adoption and critical for retailers and service providers in today's omnichannel environment. GenAI content creation diminishes followers' perceptions of brand authenticity, negatively affecting downstream attitudes and behaviors. However, followers' concerns lessen when GenAI assists rather than automates content creation. Against the background of GenAI disclosure enforcement for consumer protection, our findings stress the need for managers to take a thoughtful approach to using GenAI to maximize benefits without harming relationships with consumers.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Jasper David Brüns: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Martin Meißner:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Supervision, Resources, Methodology, Formal analysis, Conceptualization.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

During the preparation of this work, the authors used ChatGPT (OpenAI) and Claude (Anthropic) to assist in enhancing the language and readability of the manuscript. After using these tools, the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the publication.

Declaration of Competing Interest

None.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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None.

Appendix

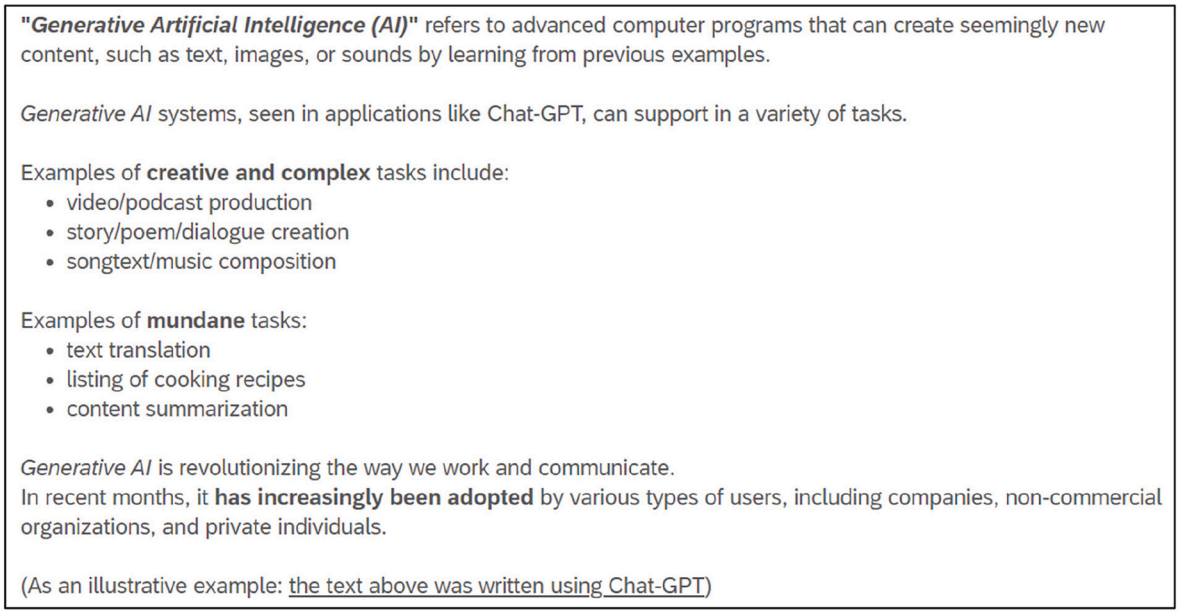


Fig. A1. Primer on generative AI (used in all studies).

Table A1
Summary of key measures

		Study 1	Study 2	Study 3
Brand Authenticity (Moulard et al., 2015)	[Brand] is *genuine*	$\alpha = 0.97$,	$\alpha = 0.96$,	$\alpha = 0.95$,
	[Brand] is *real to me*	$M = 5.12$,	$M = 4.69$,	$M = 4.48$,
	[Brand] is *authentic*	$SD = 1.71$	$SD = 1.63$	$SD = 1.87$
Post Credibility (Boerman et al., 2017)	Posts by [brand] appear *trustworthy*	$\alpha = 0.97$,	$\alpha = 0.96$,	$\alpha = 0.96$,
	Posts by [brand] appear *honest*	$M = 5.12$,	$M = 4.66$,	$M = 4.57$,
	Posts by [brand] appear *convincing*	$SD = 1.59$	$SD = 1.65$	$SD = 1.78$
EWOM Intentions (Boerman et al., 2017)	Posts by [brand] would be *worth sharing with others*	$\alpha = 0.92$,	$\alpha = 0.92$,	$\alpha = 0.94$,
	I would *like* posts by [brand]	$M = 4.96$,	$M = 4.00$,	$M = 4.73$,
	I would *comment positive feedback* below posts by [brand]	$SD = 1.61$	$SD = 1.68$	$SD = 1.62$
Brand Attitudes (Campbell, 1995)	InnoStitch is *likable*		$\alpha = 0.94$,	
	InnoStitch seems *pleasant* to me		$M = 4.82$,	
	InnoStitch products are of *high quality*		$SD = 1.46$	
Brand Loyalty	I would unfollow [brand] (reversed)	$M = 5.62$,		$M = 5.20$,
		$SD = 1.60$		$SD = 1.74$

Note: All items are measured on a seven-point agreement Likert scale (1 = *strongly disagree*, 7 = *strongly agree*); [Brand] is a placeholder for the actual embedded brand/influencer names in the respective studies; In the scenario-based Studies 1 and Study 3, items are adjusted from simple present tense to conditional mood.



Fig. A2. Study 2 brand post (anonymized).

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